Business

1. PepsiCo just reported its latest quarterly earnings, and the results were messier than expected. What was the headline story?
   a. Profits missed estimates, dragged down by weak international demand
   b. Profits missed estimates even as international sales held up well
   c. Profits beat estimates thanks to a surprise jump in US snack sales

2. Volkswagen recently proposed one of the most dramatic restructuring plans in European corporate history. What scale of job cuts did it put on the table?
   a. Around 35,000 jobs, mainly in German factories
   b. Around 65,000 jobs, focused on management layers
   c. Up to 100,000 jobs, roughly 16% of its global workforce

3. Klarna, the Swedish fintech best known for letting shoppers split purchases into instalments, has recently made a bold strategic move in the US. What did it just apply for?
   a. A US stock exchange listing to rival its planned IPO on the London Stock Exchange
   b. A US bank charter, so it can offer full banking services beyond buy-now-pay-later
   c. A US payments licence to process credit card transactions directly without Visa or Mastercard

4. A Malaysian hotpot restaurant chain listed on the Nasdaq stock exchange just signed a surprise $50 million contract. What on earth is it going to do?
   a. Open 200 new restaurants across US college campuses, backed by a private equity fund
   b. Provide support services for data centre infrastructure projects in Malaysia
   c. License its clay pot cooking technology to a Japanese kitchen appliance manufacturer

Economics

5. The US jobs report for June showed that unemployment (the share of people actively looking for work who can't find it) ticked down to 4.2%. What does that slight fall tell us about the broader picture?
   a. The labour market is booming — hiring has accelerated and wage growth is surging
   b. The labour market is cooling gradually but hasn't collapsed — fewer jobs added than May, yet unemployment still edged lower
   c. The fall is misleading — it reflects millions of workers giving up on job searches entirely

6. The European Parliament and EU governments recently entered final negotiations on creating a digital euro — a digital version of cash issued by the European Central Bank. Which of these is NOT a genuine concern being debated in those talks?
   a. How to compensate banks and payment providers who might lose business to the digital euro
   b. Whether the digital euro could give the ECB too much visibility into citizens' private spending
   c. Whether the digital euro would need to be physically printed and stored like banknotes

7. China's central bank has now increased its gold reserves for 20 consecutive months, most recently adding around 15 tonnes in June. Why does China keep buying gold?
   a. To meet rising domestic jewellery demand ahead of the Lunar New Year export season
   b. To diversify away from US dollar assets and reduce exposure to American financial influence
   c. To back a planned return to a gold standard for the Chinese yuan

8. A recent study on financial literacy (basic knowledge of money, savings, and debt) in the US produced a startling result. What share of US adults could correctly answer all eight questions on a basic financial knowledge test?
   a. About 28%
   b. About 14%
   c. About 5%

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of cobalt, the metal that is essential for electric vehicle batteries and has made it one of the most strategically important mining nations on earth?
   a. The Democratic Republic of Congo
   b. Chile
   c. Indonesia

10. Which 18th-century Scottish economist wrote the book now considered the founding text of modern capitalism, arguing that individuals pursuing their own self-interest can unintentionally benefit society — an idea he called the 'invisible hand'?
   a. David Hume
   b. Adam Smith
   c. Thomas Malthus

Business

1. PepsiCo just reported its latest quarterly earnings, and the results were messier than expected. What was the headline story?

b. Earnings missed estimates despite strong international demand. PepsiCo's global markets remained resilient, but US consumers are tightening their belts — buying fewer Doritos and Gatorades than analysts expected. It's a useful reminder that a company can be doing well abroad and still disappoint at home, which is increasingly the story for several US consumer brands right now.

2. Volkswagen recently proposed one of the most dramatic restructuring plans in European corporate history. What scale of job cuts did it put on the table?

c. Volkswagen proposed cutting up to 100,000 jobs — about 16% of its entire global workforce. The plan also involves closing factories, but it has so far failed to win backing from worker representatives on the supervisory board (the body that oversees company management). Germany's co-determination laws give workers unusually strong boardroom power, which means big restructurings can't just be handed down from the top.

3. Klarna, the Swedish fintech best known for letting shoppers split purchases into instalments, has recently made a bold strategic move in the US. What did it just apply for?

b. Klarna applied for a US bank charter, the licence that allows a firm to take deposits and operate as a proper bank. Buy-now-pay-later (a short-term instalment loan at the point of sale) built Klarna's reputation, but the margins are thin and competition is fierce. A bank charter would let it offer savings accounts, loans, and more — putting it in direct competition with JPMorgan and Bank of America, not just Afterpay.

4. A Malaysian hotpot restaurant chain listed on the Nasdaq stock exchange just signed a surprise $50 million contract. What on earth is it going to do?

b. Chicken Claypot House Holdings — yes, a hotpot restaurant — signed a three-year, $50 million contract to provide support services for data centre infrastructure in Malaysia. The company is listed on the Nasdaq despite operating in Southeast Asia, and this pivot from feeding people to powering servers is about as unexpected as corporate moves get. Malaysia has become a surprising hotspot for data centre investment, drawing interest from Google, Microsoft, and others.

Economics

5. The US jobs report for June showed that unemployment (the share of people actively looking for work who can't find it) ticked down to 4.2%. What does that slight fall tell us about the broader picture?

b. The unemployment rate dipped to 4.2%, but job creation was slower than in May — a classic picture of a labour market cooling without crashing. This matters enormously for the Federal Reserve (the US central bank), which is trying to slow inflation without triggering mass unemployment. A soft landing — lower inflation AND stable jobs — is what everyone is hoping for, and June's numbers nudged that scenario slightly closer.

6. The European Parliament and EU governments recently entered final negotiations on creating a digital euro — a digital version of cash issued by the European Central Bank. Which of these is NOT a genuine concern being debated in those talks?

c. A digital euro would exist only electronically — there's nothing to print or store physically, so that's not a real debate. The genuine tensions are about money: how banks and payment firms get compensated if people shift their spending to the state-issued digital currency, and about privacy, since a government-issued digital payment system could theoretically track every transaction you make.

7. China's central bank has now increased its gold reserves for 20 consecutive months, most recently adding around 15 tonnes in June. Why does China keep buying gold?

b. China is deliberately reducing its reliance on US dollar-denominated assets — like US Treasury bonds — by building up gold reserves instead. Gold can't be frozen or sanctioned the way dollar assets can, which matters a great deal to Beijing given geopolitical tensions with Washington. China has now added gold for 20 straight months, and it's far from alone: central banks globally have been buying gold at record rates since Russia's dollar reserves were frozen in 2022.

8. A recent study on financial literacy (basic knowledge of money, savings, and debt) in the US produced a startling result. What share of US adults could correctly answer all eight questions on a basic financial knowledge test?

c. Just 5% of US adults aced all eight questions — and that figure represents a ten-year low, meaning financial literacy is getting worse, not better. The questions covered basics like compound interest, inflation, and diversification. This isn't just a curiosity: people with low financial literacy tend to borrow more expensively, save less, and retire with significantly less wealth, so these gaps have very real consequences.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of cobalt, the metal that is essential for electric vehicle batteries and has made it one of the most strategically important mining nations on earth?

a. The Democratic Republic of Congo produces roughly 70% of the world's cobalt — a staggering concentration of supply for any single commodity. This gives one of the world's poorest countries enormous strategic importance in the global clean energy transition, but also leaves battery manufacturers dangerously exposed to political instability, supply disruptions, and ethical concerns about mining conditions.

10. Which 18th-century Scottish economist wrote the book now considered the founding text of modern capitalism, arguing that individuals pursuing their own self-interest can unintentionally benefit society — an idea he called the 'invisible hand'?

b. Adam Smith published The Wealth of Nations in 1776 — the same year as American independence — and it remains one of the most influential books ever written on economics. His 'invisible hand' metaphor described how free markets can coordinate economic activity without central planning. Smith was also a moral philosopher, and his earlier work The Theory of Moral Sentiments argued that empathy, not just self-interest, underpins a functioning society.